THE ROLE OF THE BODY IN INSTRUMENTAL AND VOCAL MUSIC PEDAGOGY

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WHO ARE WE?



Melissa Bremmer

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Embodied Music Pedagogy, Inclusive music education, ArtsSciences education



Luc Nijs

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Associate Professor in Early Childhood Music Education
Head of the Bachelor in Music Education

Embodied Music Pedagogy, Instrumental music learning, music educational technology, creativity

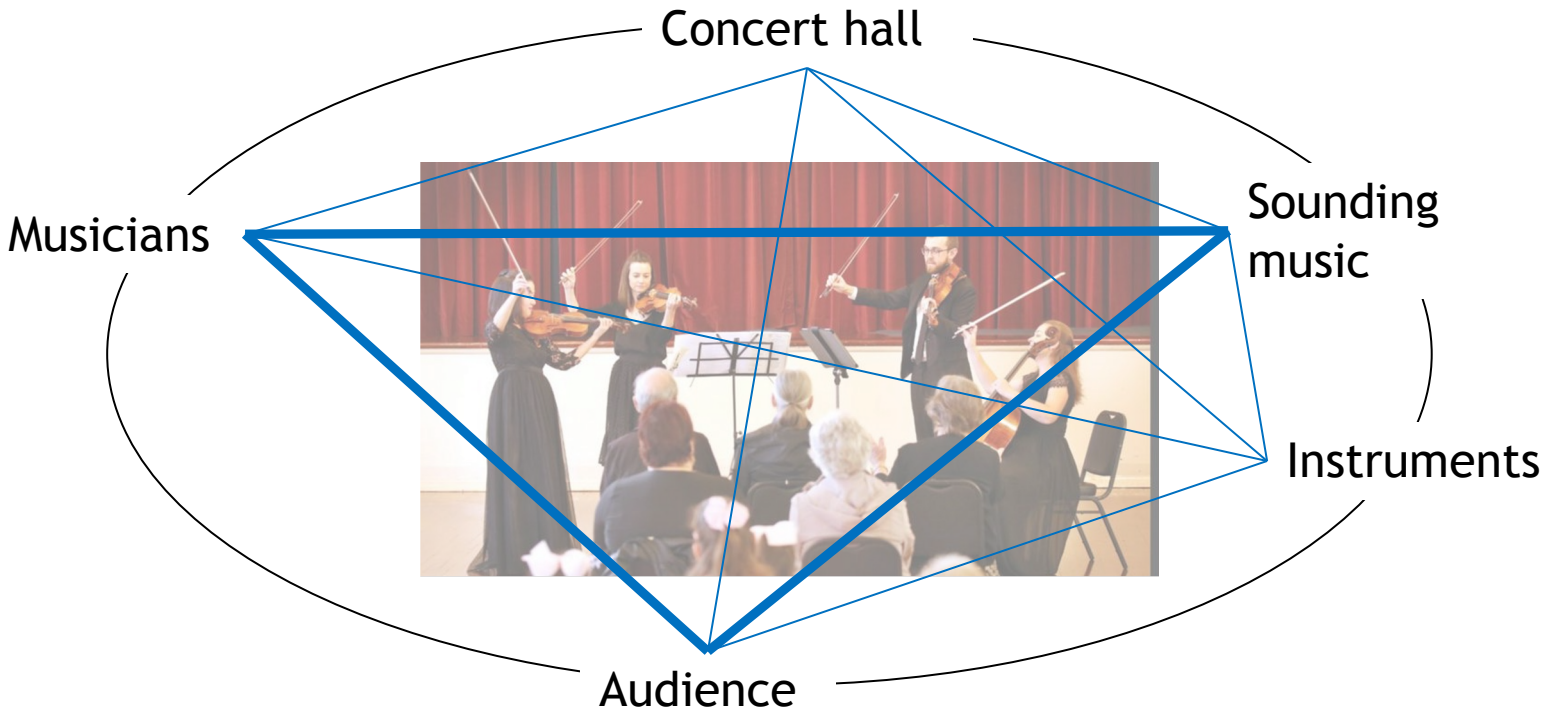
Main points

- The self-organizing behavior of the instrumentalist and vocalist can be affected by different types of constraints

- The learning process can be facilitated in non-verbal ways

DYNAMICAL SYSTEMS THEORY

Systems where the whole is always more than the sum of its parts, based on the dynamic interaction between its components, and between components and the whole
(Thelen & Smith, 2006)



Nijs, L., Bremmer, M., Van der Schyff, D. & Schiavio, A. (2023) Embodying dynamical systems in music performance. *Music Performance Research*, online first. https://doi.org/10.14439/mpr.11.3

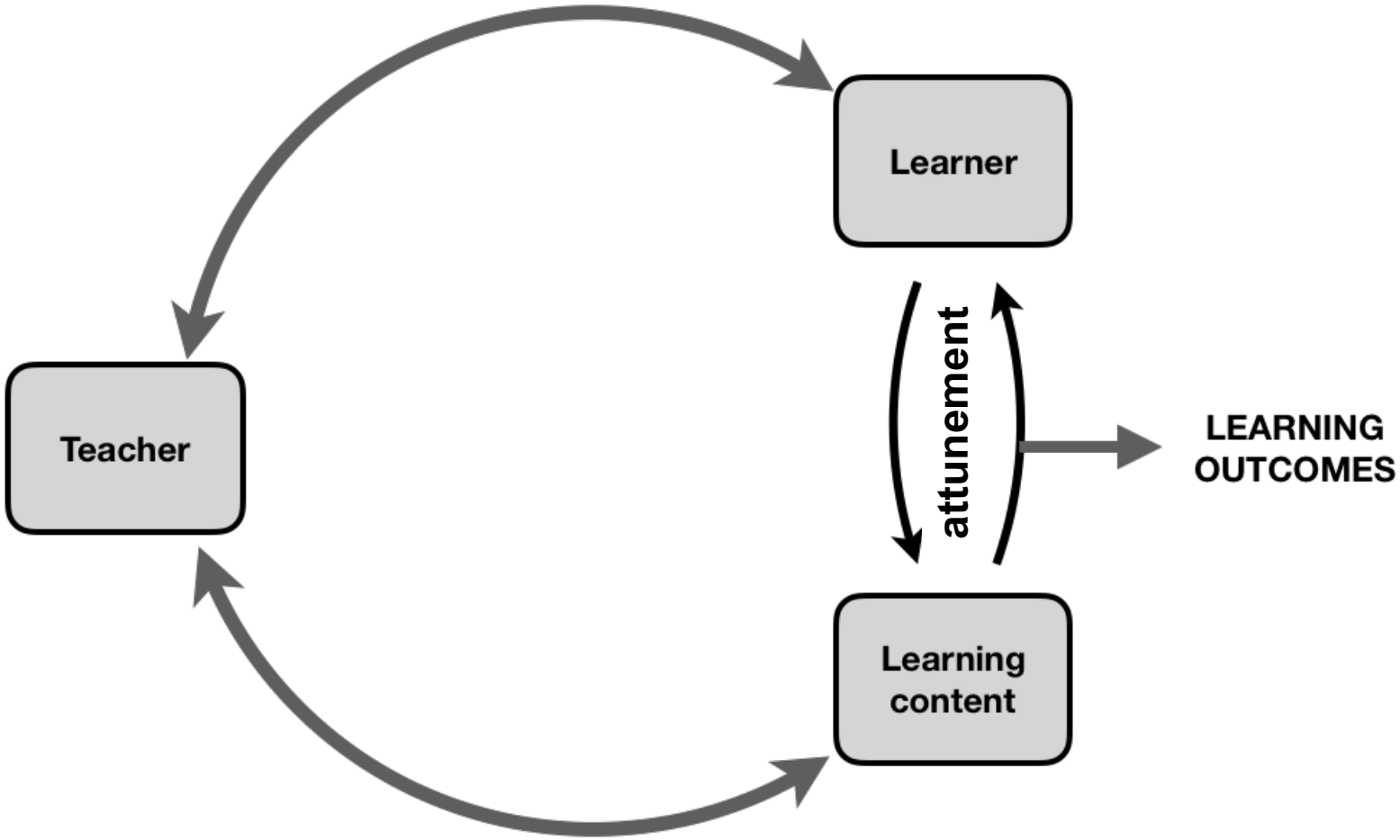
DYNAMICAL SYSTEMS THEORY & MUSIC EDUCATION



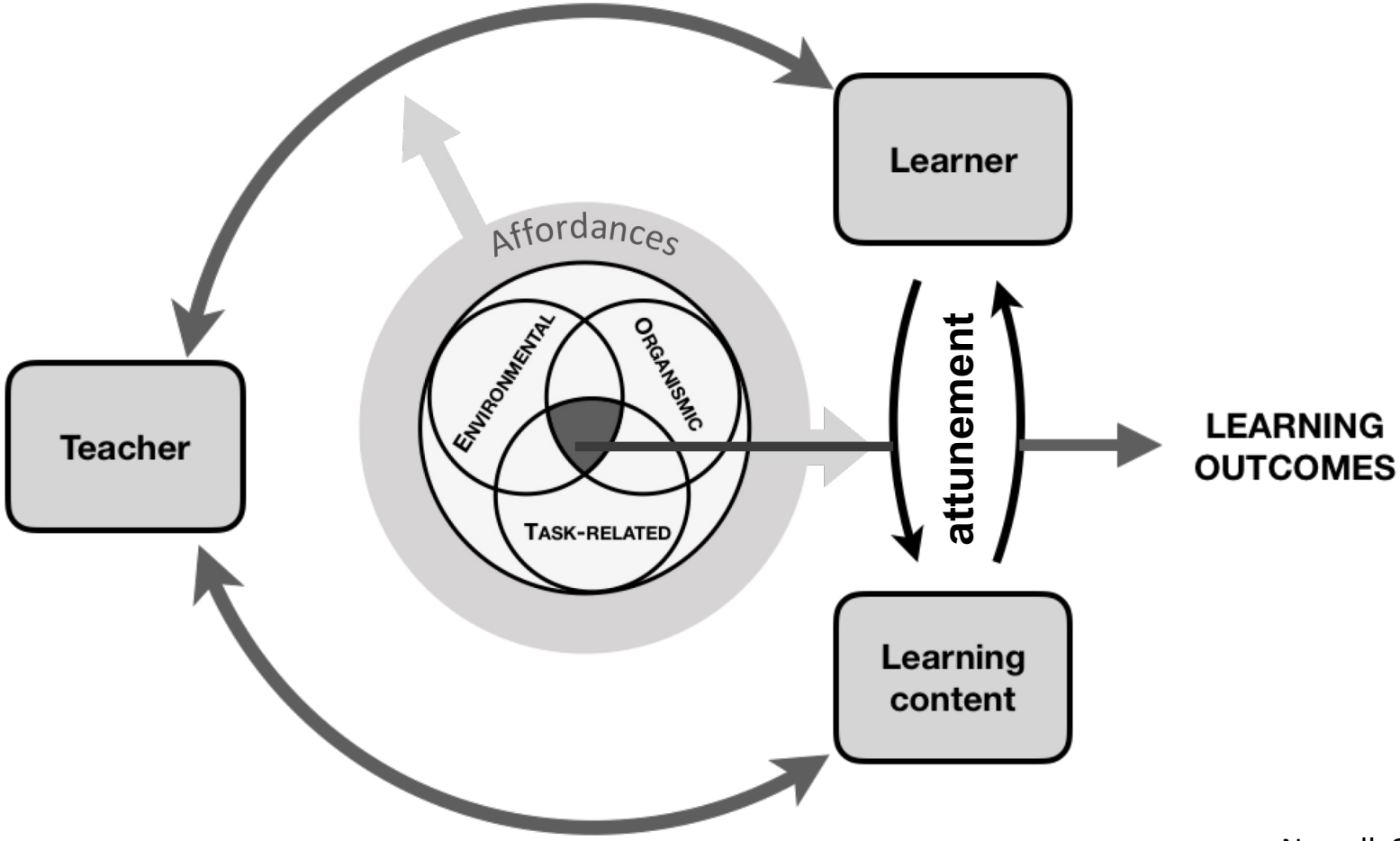
Bremmer, M. & Nijs, L. (2024). Embodiment in music education. *Journal de recherche en éducations artistiques*, 2, Special issue edited by P. Terrien & S. Chatelein, 2, 13-26. https://www.jrea.ch/article/view/4717.

Bremmer, M. & Nijs, L. (2022). Embodied Music Pedagogy. A vision on the dynamic role of the body in music education. In T. Buchborn, S. Schmid, G. Brunner, and Th. De Baets (Eds.), *European perspectives on music education: Music Is What People Do*. Helbling.

DYNAMICAL SYSTEMS THEORY & MUSIC EDUCATION



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Newell, 2003

CONSTRAINT-LED PEDAGOGY

Constraint-led pedagogy revolves around the constraints placed on an individual, shaping or limiting certain their behaviour (Davids, 2012)

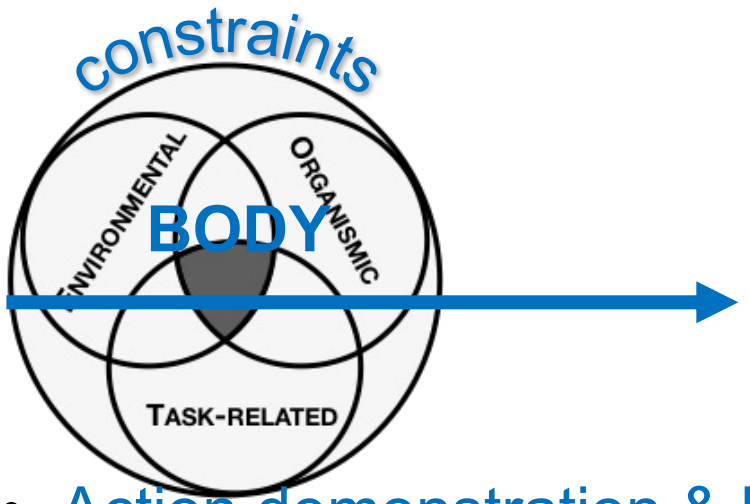
Newell (2003) distinguishes between 3 constraints:

- **Environmental: outside the individual body (incl. socio-cultural)**
- **Task: specified by the task to be performed**
- **Individual: structural (constant) & functional (change)**

Balagué, N., Pol, R., Torrents, C., Ric, A., & Hristovski, R. (2019). On the relatedness and nestedness of constraints. Sports medicine-open, 5(1), 1-10. https://doi.org/10.1186/s40798-019-0178-z

DYNAMICAL SYSTEMS THEORY & MUSIC EDUCATION

Teacher



- Action demonstration & Physical modelling
- Pedagogical gestures
- Touch

Newell, 2003

ACTION DEMONSTRATION & PHYSICAL MODELLING

Action demonstration

- Turn taking: **the teacher shows, the learner observes and imitates**
- **Instructing how to perform a musical skill** (Simones, 2017)

Physical modelling

- Simultaneous: **joint action between teacher and learner** (Simones, 2017)
- **Support and enhance the learner's performance** (Van den Dool, 2018)

ACTION DEMONSTRATION & PHYSICAL MODELLING

From a constraint-led pedagogy perspective:

Task constraint	Environmental constraint
Action demonstration	Physical modelling
Instructing the learner	Scaffolding the learner
Learner must imitate model	Learner chooses to imitate model
Teacher goal directed	Learner goal directed

ACTION DEMONSTRATION



Masterclass with Kirill Trousov

PHYSICAL MODELLING



Masterclass with Steven Isserliss

PEDAGOGICAL GESTURES

A body movement carrying an (ambiguous) intention and/or a perceived meaning for the learner (Simones et al., 2015)

(Intuitively) accompany speech, music or music making to support the learning process (Kochman et al., 2014; Nafisi, 2013a; Pearson, 2016; Simones et al., 2015)

Gestures, in contrast to language and music, have the ability to represent invisibilities and, therefore, can materialize meaning for the learner (Fatone et al., 2011).

PEDAGOGICAL GESTURES

From a constraint-led pedagogy perspective:

Task constraint	Environmental constraint
Visually directing attention	Visually reminding learner
Learner must follow instruction	Learner chooses to follow instruction
Teacher directed	Learner goal directed

PEDAGOGICAL GESTURES



Lesson with Ronald Klekamp

TOUCH

Haptic feedback, tactile modeling (Bremmer, 2015; Metz, 1989)**: similar teaching strategies of manipulating the learner's body**

Teachers also receive haptic information about learner e.g. tension in a body

Teacher must understand the ethical limits of physical contact as a pedagogical approach (McHugh-Grifa, 2011)

TOUCH

From a constraint-led pedagogy perspective:

Task constraint
Physically directing attention and providing “felt difference”
Teacher goal directed
Learner adjusts their motor-actions

TOUCH



Masterclass with Joyce DiDonato

SUMMARY
CONSTRAINT-LED PEDAGOGY IN MUSIC

Body of teacher acts both as an environmental and task constraint.

Action demonstration & Physical modeling: steer or scaffolding learner's music learning process

Pedagogical gestures: visually directing attention and/or providing a reminder

Touch: physically directing attention, providing learners with a “felt difference”

POINTS FOR DISCUSSION

- What distinguishes Task & Environmental constraints?
- To what extent can music teachers manipulate individual constraints?
- How to physically co-regulate learners in case of stress, uncertainty?

FURTHER READING…

- Bremmer, M. & Nijs, L. (2024). Embodiment in music education. *Journal de recherche en éducations artistiques*, 2, Special issue edited by P. Terrien & S. Chatelein, 2, 13-26.
- Nijs, L., Bremmer, M., Van der Schyff, D. & Schiavio, A. (2023) Embodying dynamical systems in music performance. *Music Performance Research*.
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- Nijs, L. & Bremmer, M. (2019). Embodiment and Early Childhood Music Education. In B. Ilari & S. Young. Music in Early Childhood: Multi-disciplinary Perspectives and Inter-disciplinary Exchanges (pp. 87-102). Springer International Publishing.

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